

Chapter 8

(Un)avoidable Clash: Higher Education at the Altar of Its Missions and Rankings



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8.1 Introduction

In the preface to the 2nd edition of her influential book, *Rankings and the Reshaping of Higher Education. The Battle for World-Class Excellence*, Hazelkorn (2015, pp. xix–xv) presents the following data from an international survey carried out in 2014: 84% of surveyed higher education institutions (HEIs) have established a formal internal mechanism to review their institution’s rank and “[a]n overwhelming majority of surveyed HEIs use rankings to inform strategic decisions, set targets or shape priorities”. These findings clearly demonstrate that rankings have become one of the most influential drivers behind transformations in national higher education systems, HEIs and their subunits (Hazelkorn, 2015; Marques & Powell, 2020).

An instructive example of transformation within a higher education institution (HEI) guided by the desire to improve its ranking status is the case of the University of Kentucky, USA. At the beginning of this century, the University of Kentucky was given a directive by the state legislature to achieve Top-20 status among US public universities by the year 2020. The University of Kentucky is a public land-grant institution, established in 1865, traditionally offering programmes in agriculture, engineering, mining and general liberal arts education. In order to reach the target, the university developed a strategic plan which revised its mission and value statements (DeYoung & Baas, 2012). Despite all efforts, the USNWR’s ‘Best National Universities’ ranking for 2010 was very disappointing – the University of Kentucky was ranked 129th. One of the main reasons behind this failure was the fact that the “USNWR rating system penalizes institutions that enrol considerable numbers of students with a lower statistical probability of graduating; that is, lower-income, non-traditional or minority students” (Ibid, p. 103). Thus, it turns out that the

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University of Kentucky was forced either to abandon its plan to reach a top status in the USNWR ranking or its mission as a land-grant university which strives “to increase educational access for less advantaged populations while being strongly committed to regional and state economic development” (Ibid, p. 82).

However, rankings are not only a crucial driver of transformation of higher education systems. With the upholding of knowledge-intensive societies they have become

an inevitable outcome and *metaphor for the geopolitics of HE*. Because they predominantly measure basic research and dissemination – in limited fields and in a traditional way – they provide competitive advantage to elite universities and nations which benefit from accumulated public and/or private wealth and investment over decades if not centuries. *They reflect the structure of the world economy and global science* (Hazelkorn, 2018, p. 10, emphasis added).

Against this background, the chapter discusses the tension between the plurality of missions of HEIs and global rankings, which – in most cases – are based on narrow and one-sided indicators. More specifically, the aim of this chapter is twofold. First, it is to theoretically outline a new model of the missions of higher education which captures the complexity of the influence of higher education as an institution on individuals and society. Second, it aims to critically discuss the idea of a university, upon which global rankings are based and promoted, through the prism of the developed multidimensional model of the missions of higher education.

The chapter proceeds as follows. To begin, we discuss the essence of higher education as an institution and present a multidimensional model of the missions of higher education, taking into account its intrinsic, instrumental and transformative/empowering role. This is followed by a discussion of the inevitability of global rankings in the context of massification and diversification of higher education. In the next section, the developed model of the missions of higher education is used as a prism for assessing global rankings’ neglect of the diversity of HEIs in terms of their goals and structure as well as their affirmation of only a limited understanding of the public benefit derived from higher education. The last section provides concluding remarks and asks whether it is feasible for HEIs to focus on missions instead of rankings.

8.2 Higher Education as an Institution

In order to answer what HEIs are for, we have to understand the essence of higher education.

Institutional theory argues that institutions contain cognitive-cultural and normative dimensions alongside the presumed regulative dimension and, thus, structure internalised norms of individuals (Scott & Davis, 2016). Viewing higher education as an institution means acknowledging that it is a relatively autonomous social sphere. Although embedded in and influenced by the wider social context, higher education functions according to its own specific principles and norms which may

additionally differ for different HEIs (universities/higher schools; private/public). There are important aspects of higher education which are highlighted by its understanding as an institution and which are germane to the present analysis.

First, higher education is and has been a central institution of modern societies. As Meyer et al. (2007, p. 210) put it:

[f]rom its medieval origins to its post-modern incarnation, universities are not mainly local organizations justified by specific economic and political functions or shaped by particular historical legacies or power struggles. A much broader cultural and civilizational mission has always informed higher education.

Second, in its central ‘university’ form, higher education has a history of almost a millennium and, throughout the whole period, it has nearly monopolised some very central steps in the implementation of the Western and modern-day cognitive models of progress and justice, models now circulating through the themes of excellence and equity so prevalent in higher education. Among the products of higher education are also the expanded organisational rationalisation of society, the increased globalised forms of interaction and the enhanced potential for social mobilisation (Schofer et al., 2020).

Third, albeit universities are surprisingly homogeneous in terms of cultural content throughout the world and they follow isomorphic trends in their development, organisational forms (for example, degree of autonomy or status – private or public) vary substantially across countries and even within national states.

Fourth, the understanding of higher education as an institution provides grounds for revealing and taking into account often overlooked mechanisms of socialisation and identity formation in and through higher education. More concretely, the socialising function of education is implemented not only through the formal curriculum but also through the so-called ‘hidden curriculum’, whose influence often turns out to be stronger and more important than the content of textbooks and official lectures. This hidden curriculum focuses on the implicit, unplanned, invisible messages of educational process and practices. The lessons of the hidden curriculum are ‘taught’ through the very way in which educational institutions operate and are ‘radiated’ by all their elements. The influence of higher education on students also depends on envisaging a student’s future status and role in society. Knowing what one is institutionally designed to become by a given HEI shapes individual motivation and desire to apply to it. Relying on J. W. Meyer (1970), we can claim that higher education as an institution has its own ‘social charter’. The social charter of HEIs is the “institutionalized social definitions of their products” (Meyer, 1970, p. 577), i.e., what social position each HEI can guarantee its students in society, or what future it can hold out to them. HEIs which are chartered to confer major status gains and entry into prestigious social groups (elites) are seen as more likely to have broad effects on their students.

Fifth, as an institution, higher education “has an impact on society over and above the immediate socializing experiences it offers the young” (Meyer, 1977, p. 55). At the level of the individual, this influence is mainly associated with the identity-formation effects of entering higher education and acquiring the status of

student/graduate. An individual's opportunities and expectations are substantially transformed when s/he becomes a college graduate, and this transformation is independent of the particular student experience (Meyer, 1970). At the societal level, conceiving higher education as an institution, not only as an organisation for producing trained individuals, allows us to see that "the university serves a highly collective function". It links the "role structure of society to universalized cultural knowledge" and "defines certain types of knowledge as authoritative in society, and authoritative on the basis of the highest cultural principles (e.g., science, rationality, natural law)" (Meyer et al., 2007, pp. 206–207). Higher education – to a much greater extent than the other levels of education – "constructs and alters the network of positions in society in addition to allocating individuals to these positions" and "confers success and failure in society quite apart from any socializing effects" (Meyer, 1977, pp. 56, 64). In terms of social differentiation and a strong social division of labour, it is common practice for people to be allocated to different social roles based on the number of years and type of school they have completed without really taking into account what knowledge and skills they have acquired. Moreover, unlike the socialisation effect of higher education that matters only to those exposed to its impact, the distributional role of higher education has significant implications for both the individuals included in the system and those who remain outside it. Higher education is revealed as an institution that, through legitimising a section of young people as successful, labels and 'stigmatises' others as 'failures.' These processes are extremely important for affirming students' positive social worth but also for creating recognition gaps.

8.2.1 *Model of Higher Education Missions*

According to C. Kerr (1963, pp. 8–9), "[t]he university is so many things to so many people that it must, of necessity, be partially at war with itself". Nevertheless, it is evident that the *raison d'être* of higher education in contemporary societies consists simultaneously of three purposes – teaching, research and service (Tight et al., 2009). Specific higher education systems and HEIs combine these three missions and the activities associated with them in different manners by putting stress on one or the other.

Within the framework of the capability approach, Drèze and Sen (2002, pp. 38–40) outline five different ways in which education can be valuable to the freedom of a person: intrinsic importance, instrumental personal roles, instrumental social roles, instrumental process roles and empowerment and distributive roles. Relying on this distinction between the various roles of education and taking into account the above-described specificity of higher education as an institution, Boyadjieva and Ilieva-Trichkova (2016) have developed a normative theoretical model of the missions/roles of higher education. The model follows two lines of reasoning: (1) *level of influence*: individual or societal, and (2) *character of influence*: intrinsic, instrumental or transformative/empowering.

A further developed version of this model is presented below (see Table 8.1).

The model clearly demonstrates the complex nature and plurality of the missions and values of higher education as an institution. At the individual level, it differentiates the missions/roles of higher education related to different aspects of personality development, alongside graduates' employability, and classifies them according to their instrumental, intrinsic or transformative/empowering value. At the societal

Table 8.1 Normative model of missions of higher education as an institution

Level of influence Character of influence	Individual	Society
Instrumental	Increasing employability (formation of learners' abilities to find employment by developing relevant knowledge, skills, attitudes, identities) Formation of status identity as a learner Certification of graduates	Human development (viewed as improvement of human capital) Promotion of economic growth and innovation Stratification of different types of knowledge/disciplines Reproduction of (and change in) the professional structure of society and legitimisation of new professional roles Diversification of cultural and intellectual centres
Intrinsic	Valuing and acquiring knowledge for its own sake	Creation and transmission of knowledge Legitimisation of different types of knowledge Legitimisation of specific values in society: rationality, equity (as both inclusion and fairness), trust, tolerance, freedom of thought, diversity Promotion of human understanding within and beyond national borders
Transformative/ empowering	Personality development Formation of responsible identity Gaining recognition Development of abilities for independent and critical thinking and imagination Agency development and empowerment to control one's environment Promoting individual mobility Promoting individual participation in social and political life and decision-making processes	Human development (understood as a process of expanding the real freedoms that people enjoy) (Re)distribution – facilitating social group mobility and the ability of different groups, disadvantaged included, to organise and express their interests Representation – facilitating participation of social groups in social and political life and in decision-making processes

Source: A revised version of the model, presented in Boyadjieva and Ilieva-Trichkova (2016, p. 50)

level, in addition to the widely discussed role of higher education for economic and cultural development, the model highlights its role for the societal legitimisation of different types of knowledge and values and its human development role from two different perspectives: an instrumental one, in terms of improvement of the population's knowledge and skills, and an empowering one, in terms of expanding the actual freedoms that people enjoy.

The model represents an ideal type in the Weberian sense – it has no ontological reality and is simply a cognitive instrument for capturing the diversity of missions/roles of higher education as an institution. Missions of higher education are embedded in different social and organisational contexts and can be studied at two levels – at the level of each specific HEI and at the supra-institutional level, being it national, regional or global.

8.3 The Inevitability of Highly-Criticised University Rankings

One of the most prominent features of the development of higher education as an institution in recent years has been “the dominance of global and national rankings (or league tables) in driving institutional efforts to gain competitive advantage” (Bowl, 2018, p. 2). On the one hand, there is a generally shared conviction that “rankings are here to stay” and there is “nowhere to hide” from them (Hazelkorn, 2014, p. 23; Marginson, 2014, p. 45). On the other, rankings have been the target of constant criticism (Dill & Soo, 2005; Gonzales & Núñez, 2014; Marginson, 2009; Marginson & Van der Wende, 2007; Teichler, 2011a; Usher & Savino, 2007; Van Dyke, 2005). At first glance, this situation appears paradoxical. However, in view of the specifics of higher education and its developments over the last few decades, the appearance of rankings is something inevitable, as are the constant criticisms levelled against them.

Philip Altbach (2011, p. 2) claims that “[i]f rankings did not exist, someone would invent them”. The growing interest in rankings of HEIs and the establishment of increasingly numerous and diverse rankings are an inevitable result of radical changes emerging in the sphere of higher education in all countries of the world in the second half of the twentieth century and especially in the beginning of the present century (Hazelkorn, 2015; Hazelkorn, 2018; Marques & Powell, 2020; Schofer & Meyer, 2005; Teichler, 2011b). The trends in question are:

- the massification of higher education and the growing diversity of students in HEIs;
- increased competition within national systems of higher education and at the international level;
- the internationalisation of higher education and the rise of the international academic labour market;

- the commercialisation of higher education and the entry of market mechanisms;
- the diversification of institutions offering post-secondary education;
- the changed status of knowledge in modern societies and its increasing economic role;
- the increased importance of higher education as a barometer of national competitiveness;
- the rise of the ‘audit society’ (Power, 1997) in which accountability and evaluation have become norms.

Under these circumstances, the potential ‘clients’ of HEIs, such as students and their families and employers, are seeking information so as to make better-informed choices amidst the diversity of offered programmes. For its part, every HEI needs common, objective criteria and indicators for measuring its performance in comparison with other HEIs and to ascertain its specific place on the market of education services. Not least, the need for a comparative view of how different HEIs are functioning is deeply felt at the policy level when concrete higher education policies are grounded and elaborated.

Rankings have emerged as an instrument for the evaluation of HEIs within national systems of higher education. With the massification of higher education, and especially the unfolding processes of globalisation, the need arises for a common comparative assessment of higher education in all countries. The first global ranking of HEIs was conducted in 2003 by the Institute of Higher Education at Shanghai Jiao Tong University. The next was that of Times Higher, published in 2004. In the following years, several other global rankings established themselves, including that of Leiden University, Scimago, QS World University Rankings and the European U-Multirank system.

These different ranking systems are based on multiple kinds of information and data gleaned from various sources. An in-depth comparative study of the global rankings (Marginson, 2014) shows that there is no perfect ranking and each of the best-known global rankings has its advantages and shortcomings. As soon as they appeared, all the ranking systems were subjected to numerous criticisms by representatives of different social groups, especially the academic community (see for example: Teichler, 2011a, pp. 62–66). Very importantly, according to many authors, there is an accumulation of biases inherent in rankings. Undoubtedly, global rankings favour research-intensive institutions with strengths in hard sciences, universities that use English, older institutions in countries with long-held traditions, HEIs in countries with steep hierarchies and those with little intra-institutional diversity (Altbach, 2011; Kehm, 2014; Teichler, 2011a). University rankings are defined as ‘unfair’ – which is not due to the technique of measurement but rather their usages and the rationale for their existence. Li et al. (2011, p. 923) argue that:

[a] large amount of cross-country variation in university performance can be explained by just four socioeconomic factors: income, population size, research and development spending, and the national language.

Rankings are seen as a driver of “a market-like competition in higher education” (Marginson, 2014, p. 47) and as an instrument to “normalize and to justify existing social divisions” in stratification and organisational segmentation (Cantwell & Taylor, 2013, p. 220), to “confirm, entrench and reproduce prestige and power” in higher education (Marginson, 2009, p. 600, emphasis added). The ranking of HEIs is also defined as:

a formidable machinery of symbolic and economic power... a politico-ideological technology that serves not the educational needs of students or teachers, but rather the interests of the global elite (Amsler & Bolsmann, 2012, p. 286, emphasis added).

8.4 Ranking Systems Through the Prism of the Multidimensional Model of the Missions of Higher Education

The developed multidimensional model of the missions of higher education provides a specific prism through which we can see the idea of higher education promoted and legitimated by (global) ranking systems. As Hazelkorn (2019, p. 9) rightly highlights, there is no doubt that “rankings drive behavior”, but the important question is in what direction, and it must be acknowledged that “the direction of travel depends upon the choice of indicators.” The directions in which rankings drive – and even push – HIEs are very important as they effect HEIs’ relations with national state and their place – and also the place of different nations – on the global landscape of knowledge.

8.4.1 *Rankings Affirm a One-Fits-All HEI and Neglect the Diversity of HEIs in Terms of Their Goals and Structure*

As a rule, all ranking systems, especially the global ones, consider certain kinds of HEIs to be the norm – these include research universities that stress the natural sciences. Moreover, they apply “a rather narrow definition of quality or performance on the basis of a ‘one-fits-all’ measurement by using the same set of indicators for all institutions” (Kehm, 2014, p. 104). Thus, they enhance the prestige of some institutions at the expense of others. For example, the technical and professional HEIs that – in countries like Germany (e.g., Fachhochschulen), Finland, Switzerland and France – have long traditions and are among the most prestigious HEIs are under-evaluated in global rankings (Marginson & Van der Wende, 2007).

8.4.2 Rankings Affirm a Limited Understanding as to the Public Benefit Derived from Higher Education

In attaching the greatest weight to indicators connected with research productivity or faculty publications and citations, global rankings legitimise higher education simply with respect to its contribution to the production of new knowledge. As a rule, rankings leave out of the picture the role of HEIs as a source of critical sensitivity in democratic society – a role that was, for example, especially prominent in the years of transition from totalitarianism to democracy in Central and Eastern European countries or in France in the 1960s. Also, global rankings disregard the benefit yielded by higher education in promoting goals such as improved access for students from traditionally underrepresented groups, increased affordability of high-quality post-secondary education, contributions to community development or social justice (Pusser & Marginson, 2013). This is a very important role of higher education, having in mind that although the expansion of higher education is inclusive, there are still great differences in its fairness – that is, in the chances for children from different social and educational backgrounds to attain higher education (Arum et al., 2007; Boyadjieva & Ilieva-Trichkova, 2020).

Regional and community engagement indicators are very rarely present in the majority of both national and international rankings. Attempts have recently emerged to develop meaningful measures for the civic and regional mission of HEIs, in countries such as the Netherlands, Sweden and the UK, or these have been initiated by the European Commission within the framework of some projects. However, the validation process and analyses show that these attempts have not succeeded in satisfactorily capturing HEIs' social and civic contributions (Benneworth & Zeeman, 2018; Farnell, 2020).

It should be emphasised that some of the global rankings have undertaken important steps in order to more broadly recognise the public benefit of higher education and to take into account the diversity of HEIs in their missions and strengths. In 2015 the European U-Multirank model included measures for regional engagement, such as graduate retention, student internships, joint publication and commercial income relating to the region. The OS Stars University Rankings awards HEIs for achievements in specific areas, which include (in addition to research) graduate employability, social responsibility and inclusiveness. Thus, social responsibility measures HEIs' engagement via investing in the local community, charity work, regional human capital development and raising environmental awareness. In 2019 *Times Higher Education* launched its University Impact Ranking. It measures schools' activity aligned with 11 of the 17 UN Sustainability Development Goals. Although these developments should be welcomed and encouraged, at present they rather reinforce the peripheral importance of the third mission of HEIs in comparison to research activity. This is evident from the fact that these are additional

rankings, whereas the main rankings of both *Times Higher Education* and QS continue to put stress on research productivity and academic reputation. Additionally, the measurement of social impact relies predominantly on data reported by the HEIs themselves, which seriously puts their reliability into question. Attempts to measure the societal impact of HEIs sharpen the fundamental problem of all rankings, namely that they rely only on quantitative indicators. There is good reason to argue that:

[t]here is something dehumanising in seeking to put a number on *every* particle of human activity, however worthy the aim; and finding the appropriate balance between quantitative and qualitative modes of evaluation is task that demands constant vigilance and negotiation (Stephen, 2019, blog post).

8.4.3 (Global) Rankings Do Not Encourage Diversification of Higher Education

Data show that, since the beginning of the twenty-first century, the number of students in higher education has more than doubled with much of this expansion taking place in newly established HEIs (Altbach, 2019). Most of these institutions are local with a main focus on teaching and widening access to higher education for diverse social groups. Having in mind the fact that global rankings overemphasise research productivity, it is out of doubt that most of these new HEIs would not appear in them as their missions are at odds with the rankings indicators. Additionally, “[n]ewer and smaller universities, especially in developing economies, and institutions without these specialisations, have limited opportunities” because “without massive financial and other resources, it is almost impossible for academic institutions to improve their ranking status” (Altbach & Hazelkorn, 2017). Thus rankings represent “*disparities in resources and the unevenness in the global production of knowledge*, the effect of which is to legitimize such inequities” (Hazelkorn, 2018, p. 18, emphasis added). Those new universities which have succeeded to find a prestigious place in the global rankings, as for example Jacobs University in Bremen, Germany, are research-intensive with a strong international orientation.¹

¹ However, the recent developments in Jacobs University in Bremen have demonstrated how difficult it is for a young university to preserve such a profile. The University has fallen under severe financial stress because neither the foundation behind it nor the Land of Bremen want to fund it any longer, see: <https://www.forschung-und-lehre.de/politik/jacobs-stiftung-foerdert-privatuni-nicht-mehr-2931/>

8.4.4 *(Global) Rankings Do Not Take into Account the Value Added Achieved by HEIs and Are Susceptible to the ‘Halo’ Effect*

(Global) rankings do not pay attention to the different starting positions of HEIs. Most importantly, they do not reward the development, degree or speed of improvement and performance. For example, nearly all HEIs in Central and East European countries started out at low positions or have yet to succeed in being included in the rankings. So, it is important for them to have as an incentive a measure of the value rankings add to their performance, even if they might fail to find a place in the top positions.

Global rankings are susceptible to the ‘halo’ effect. Two of the global rankings – *Times Higher Education World University Rankings* and *QS World University Rankings* – work with reputational indicators. However, as a rule, studies measuring the prestige of HEIs reproduce prestige that has already been established, regardless of actual achievements. According to Marginson (2014, p. 46),

[r]anking reinforces the advantages enjoyed by leading universities. It celebrates their status and propels more money and talent towards them, helping them to stay on top. It is difficult for outsiders, emerging universities and countries to break in. Rankings are not “fair” to competing universities. The starting positions are manifestly unequal.

8.4.5 *Rankings Affirm a Narrow or Misleading Definition of Quality of Higher Education*

Comparative studies on rankings (Marginson, 2014; Usher & Savino, 2007; Van Dyke, 2005) have definitely shown that these systems differ in their goals, scope, methodology and the kind and reliability of data used. These differences are so great that no two systems are alike and, between systems, there is not even a single coinciding indicator (Usher & Savino, 2007, p. 28). All classifications claim to rank HEIs by quality – ‘the best universities’, ‘top 100 universities’, ‘top 500 universities’. But not a single ranking gives a definition of quality of higher education, and there is no generally shared understanding on this concept or how it should be measured. As Hazelkorn (2015, p. xvi) rightly outlines:

[l]ots of data is being collected, and there are plenty of indicators, but there is no internationally agreed definition or methodology, no objective or value-free set of indicators, and no common international dataset.

Looking at how the indicators used are related to the concept of quality of higher education, we can identify the following trends. (1) Although to a lesser degree than other rankings, global rankings include indicators related to the conditions, prerequisites and results of quality education. (2) All global rankings employ indicators for measuring research activity, and moreover, it is given very great importance. (3)

Unlike national rankings, global ones have no indicators based on the opinion of students about the quality of the teaching process. (4) Global rankings use no indicators that directly reflect the quality of educational results, whether this can be assessed by an external, independent assessment of the knowledge and skills of graduates or by considering their professional realization. The only exception to this feature is found in the Academic Ranking of World Universities of Shanghai Jiao Tong University, which includes as indicators the alumni of an institution who have won Nobel Prizes and Fields Medals.

In recent years, through the project “Assessment of Higher Education Learning Outcomes” (AHELO) of the Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD), an attempt was made to achieve some form of unified measure of the knowledge and skills of graduates, similar to the Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA) survey of students in secondary education (Tremblay et al., 2012). However, the assessments obtained by the feasibility study are rather contradictory, and many scholars have defined it as a failure. Philip Altbach (2015) argues that, because courses and curricula vary significantly across countries, “AHELO would be testing apples and oranges, not to mention kumquats and broccoli”. The presidents of leading US and Canadian universities pointed out that “AHELO fundamentally misconstrues the purpose of learning outcomes, which should be to allow institutions to determine and define what they expect students will achieve and to measure whether they have been successful in doing so” (Husbands, 2015). In turn, the supporters of AHELO feel that institutional opposition to AHELO is:

a defense of privilege: top universities know they will do well on comparisons of prestige and research intensity. They don't know how they will do on comparisons of teaching and learning (Usher, 2015: 1).

This intensive discussion has once again clearly demonstrated the difficulties arising in defining and measuring quality of higher education, as well as the fact that the ranking systems do not represent a neutral technical instrument but serve as a basic mechanism for the affirmation and redistribution of positions in higher education.

8.5 Discussion and Concluding Remarks: Is a Focus on Missions Instead of Rankings Possible?

Drawing upon the institutional perspective towards higher education, this chapter has elaborated a multidimensional model of the missions of higher education. The model is an attempt to provide a broader vision for higher education which acknowledges the intrinsic, instrumental and transformative/empowering role of higher education as an institution at both individual and societal levels. The developed model of the missions of higher education is used as lens for critical assessment of global rankings as: (1) neglecting the diversity of HEIs in terms of their missions, goals

and structures; (2) affirming a limited understanding of the public benefit derived from higher education; and (3) promoting a misleading understanding of quality of higher education.

Some authors claim that “the ‘naturalness’ and ‘inevitability’ of rankings are political positions” and that the “assertion that ‘rankings are here to stay’ is not an objective representation of reality” (Amsler & Bolsmann, 2012, p. 291). In an article published in *University World News* in 2017, two of the leading scholars in the field of higher education and university rankings – Philip Altbach and Ellen Hazelkorn – strongly argue that it is high time for HEIs to forget about and even quit rankings and that they should “*focus on missions, not on ranking*”. Based on the discussion above, this claim sounds reasonable and desirable. However, is this feasible or plausible, having in mind the development of higher education and its place in contemporary, highly dynamic and knowledge-intensive societies? Below are some arguments that, even if HEIs manage to ‘forget’ about rankings, they will hardly be able to quit them nor undermine their public and institutional importance.

The first argument refers to the specificity of higher education as a field. Adhering to the neo-institutional framework, Gonzales and Núñez (2014, p. 5) define higher education as a cultural field and outline that, as such:

it does not produce goods that are easily or objectively measurable. Unlike an organization that might produce pencils or cars, post-secondary organizations produce knowledge through highly social, interactional, and tacit processes of teaching and learning.

Thus, neo-institutionalism explains the importance HEIs put on rankings and the power of rankings with the fact that they mirror the specificity of higher education as a social field and provide cultural resources, for example legitimacy and prestige, to HEIs in their aspirations for success. According to some authors, “prestige is to higher education what profit is to corporations” (Gonzales & Núñez, 2014, p. 5).

Secondly, the neo-institutional perspective also outlines the way HEIs have been developed over the last century as increasingly rationalised organisational actors embedded in an international environment. Thus, Ramirez (2013, pp. 143 f.) argues that the key to the puzzle “Why are universities now ranked? And why are they ranked across national borders?”

lies in the movement from national, historical institutions to rationalized organizations. The general idea is that the more any entity is imagined as a rationalized organization, the more it is at risk of being compared to other entities. . . the rationalized organization image undermines the historicity and distinctiveness of the entities by dangling portable “best practices” before them. What are then compared are aspects of the entities rather than the entities as a whole.

Thirdly, the power of rankings not only within the higher education sector but also among nation states resembles the increased importance of higher education in knowledge-based societies. As Hazelkorn (2018, p. 17) emphasises, higher education’s “foremost role in talent maximization and knowledge production makes it integral to national and global power relations”. She further explains that:

HE is at the centre of geopolitical relations, transformed from being a predominantly social institution with a local or subnational remit to being the cornerstone of economic policy with geopolitical responsibilities... Institutions and nations are measured against each other, highlighting comparative and competitive global advantages and disparities in capacity and capability, and reflecting a world-order in flux (Ibid, p. 16, emphasis added).

Having top-ranked HEIs can improve country's international prestige and reputation. As Cantwell (2016, p. 316, emphasis added) outlines "*rankings constitute one marker of state power*". They also "may boost a state's soft power insofar as the rankings represent a nation's higher education system as strong or 'excellent'" (ibid, p. 317).

Fourthly, when discussing whether HEIs can 'forget' about rankings and quit them, we should pay attention to the fact that rankings and their results have become a valuable 'currency' in the relationships within the higher education sector and between HEIs and their 'clients' (students, employers, governments). Many of the indicators used in rankings (e.g., citations, publications, projects, grants) are widely present and applied within HEIs for individual academic promotion and department evaluation and, thus, they strongly effect knowledge production (Gonzales & Núñez, 2014; Ramírez, 2013). 'De-coupling' of HEIs from the pressure of rankings would be difficult to achieve:

due to their over-determining influence on institutional status and reputation, student choice and graduate recruitment, the views and opinions of government, employers and peer institutions, and overall societal confidence in institutions (Hazelkorn, 2018, p. 9).

Fifth, even if some HEIs stop paying attention to rankings, this will not mean that they will cease to be visible or become invisible in them due to one simple and more technical reason – the fact that the most prestigious rankings use data from big research data sets and from reputational surveys. The main global rankings do not rely on data obtained from HEIs and, in this sense, they do not depend on 'their will' but on data which are available and easily accessible.

When discussing the role of rankings in the strategic development of HEIs and their mission statements, it is worth recalling an interview with Nunzio Quacquarelli – the founding partner of Quacquarelli Symonds (QS), which launched the annual World University Rankings in 2004 with the then *Times Higher Education Supplement*. He said:

What we've been surprised by is the extent to which governments and university leaders use the rankings to set strategic targets. We at QS think this is wrong. Rankings are a relative measure – if other universities do better and move up, you have to go faster... *Ranks should not be a primary driver of university mission statements and visions*. But ranks can be a useful provider of data (Quoted in Sharma, 2010, emphasis added).

The most important criterion fused in global rankings is the research productivity measured mainly by the number of publications indexed in world research platforms and by the number of citations. This raises the following crucial question regarding the national higher education policies: What kinds of HEIs figure in the concrete national system of higher education, and how are they defined in terms of the performed research? In formulating countries' stances on this question,

policymakers and the academic community in each country should well have in mind the opinion of leading researchers that “[un]evenness in research performance is inevitable, if not necessary to creativity itself” (Marginson, 2011: 32). But they should also take into consideration that:

[e]xperience indicates that it is not possible to create several world-class universities (with prospects for a sustainable future) in any one country without investing in the national higher education system as a whole (Yudkevich et al., 2015, p. 415).

Rankings are certainly an important source of information and an instrument for measuring and comparing the achievements of HEIs by certain indicators. But they are only one of the mechanisms – and not a perfect one at that – for assessing the quality of higher education. That is why a great challenge for policymakers and for the academic community is to strengthen and use rankings to stimulate, not to penalize, the development of concrete HEIs and national systems of higher education.

The clash between the missions of higher education and the way HEIs are assessed by (global) rankings raises some important questions which deserve further and in-depth investigation:

How can, and how should, quality of higher education be defined?

How can strategic thinking in higher education be promoted in the context of the daily struggle with financial constraints and bureaucracy?

How can the values of diversity, quality and social justice be simultaneously maintained in higher education?

How can the missions of HEIs be diversified and further developed by incorporating a bottom-up approach that acknowledges not only the instrumental but also the intrinsic and transformative/empowering value of higher education at both individual and societal levels?

The globalising world we are living in has created a radically new social environment. In the words of Bauman (1997, p. 25), the post-modern world is a “multivocal world of uncoordinated needs, self-procreating possibilities and self-multiplying choices”, “a world in which no one can anticipate the kind of expertise that may be needed tomorrow”. In such a world, he continues:

the recognition of many and varied ways to, and many and varied canons of, higher learning is the condition *sine qua non* of the university system capable of rising to the postmodern challenge... [Therefore,] it is the good luck of the universities that there are so many of them, that there are no two exactly alike... (Ibid.).

It is obvious that there is no perfect ranking and – what is more important – no single ranking can take into account all different models of HEIs. That is why the diversity of HEIs’ missions and roles can be captured only by a diversity of rankings and their complementarity with other instruments for accountability and transparency.

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